

But there was no switch to flip to turn off the dopamine hits of shopping. Allison struggled with feelings of anger for getting into debt, resentment of her budget, and guilt for still wanting to “spend to zero” with a baby on the way. But she stuck with it. And after four or five months, she felt a shift.

“In the beginning, I valued everything because that’s what the world told me to do. But I truly didn’t understand what I valued spending money on. It took me not spending money for a time, and then slowly introducing those things back into my spending, for me to see what I value.” It wasn’t easy, but that season began to show her the things she didn’t value so she could spend without guilt on the things she did value. Allison and Matt paid off their six-figure debt in less than five years. Along the way she realized she didn’t value the “deals” at the store as much as she thought. Instead, she wanted to travel. While they did do some traveling while paying off debt, it was minimal. Now that they’re debt-free and her kids are out of daycare, they take amazing camping trips to national parks and even surprise trips to Disney! But the freedom to spend on that only came after a season in which they prioritized paying off debt.

Prioritization is simply defining what matters most and tackling those things in sequence. It’s the key to buying what we want on a limited income and it’s what helps us recognize that if everything is important, nothing is important. This is where we start to define how to afford the things we love, especially the physical things, and the financial goals we need to pursue to get more of the things we value that money can’t buy. Prioritization doesn’t make any one need or goal less worthwhile. It simply conserves our limited resources, tangible and intangible, to give us the best and fullest life possible in every season. It’s what helps us to say no to things that don’t matter and yes to things that do.

So how do we define what matters most?

First, we need to think about those four F’s and what we want from each of those areas: with our family and friends, in our faith communities, and fulfilling work. For Allison, she obviously valued her new baby! But she also loved her work as a teacher and didn’t want to leave. They decided paying off their debt faster would be the best way to free up more income for the future.

When we think about making financial goals, we live by this principle: *What’s one thing I can do now that will get me more of what I value in the future?* There’s no shortage of good financial goals out there, but with a